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From the editor-in-chief

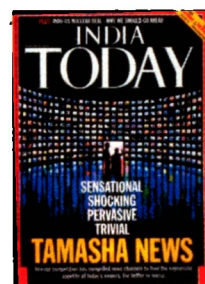
It has been said that television is a weapon of mass distraction. That is what it seems to have become in India. For a large number of Indians, it is a dinner table companion, an all-day babysitter and a late night sleep aid. There is no shortage of what you want to watch. You name it and it is there. Already there are 75 million cable and satellite homes in India, expected to go up to 90 million by 2013. There are 480 channels in all and counting, up from 120 in 2003. The entire TV market currently, including subscriptions, is Rs 24,000 crore, of which advertising revenue is pegged at Rs 8,200 crore. The numbers are expected to go up to Rs 47,300 crore for the total market and Rs 15,500 crore for advertising revenue in six years. In this space, the Hindi entertainment channels, which form 25 per cent of the entire market, have the largest chunk of viewers and revenue among all the genres. An estimated 113 million people watch these channels. The last 18 months alone have seen four major launches in this segment by big broadcasters with deep pockets. Not surprisingly, there is a bitter battle for what the industry crudely calls eyeballs. It is vital for them to know which eyeballs watch what and for how long as their revenues depend on that.

GRPs (gross rating points) is the god they worship.

These new players have changed the rules of the game. And how. If the GRPs of Star Plus were 321 in August 2008, they fell to 293 this month, while Colors went up from 116 to 308. But it wasn't just a question of shifting numbers. The nature of how we are entertained has changed, from the *Ramayan* and *Mahabharat* of 1986 and 1988 to the *saas-bahu* soaps ushered in on the back of the most recent transformative show on TV, *Kaun Banega Crorepati*, in 2000. That was a foreign format, setting the pattern for what followed. Hindi entertainment channels now tend to rely on the big foreign shows for buzz, reiterating the universality of human emotions, and depend on the conventional soaps for their bread and butter. That is why three major channels have shared the top spot in the past two months. This has put the whole industry in a flux and has made broadcasters put on air programmes ranging from the bizarre to the ridiculous. Indians have been witness to increasingly regressive soaps and progressively edgy reality shows. If the child marriage blockbuster *Balika Vadhu* has seen several clones, some even going as far afield as Bihar to look for a story on bride buying, then channel representatives have been scouring TV markets looking for the next big foreign adaptation.

But the messy smorgasbord on TV merely reflects what is happening around us, where people are trying to negotiate being global as well as Indian. There are outdated social practices and there are new relationships that are emerging where women like Rakhi Sawant are walking the thin line between exploitation and empowerment, while shows such as *Sacch ka Saamna* are poised between outright voyeurism and on-air catharsis. The audience that watches the elaborate marriage conventions of this week's top rated show, *Yeh Rishta Kya Kehlata Hai*, is also deeply interested in whether the bright-eyed homemaker will dish the dirt on her formerly alcoholic husband on *Sacch ka Saamna*. As one of the writers of the story, Principal Correspondent Jhilmil Motihar, says, "Watching TV is like a shockathon. If an actress admitting to getting pregnant at 16 won't shock you, then a woman being bought to produce a male heir for a rich feudal family in Bihar will." As one show would say, "entertainment *ke liye kuch bhi karega*".

(Aroon Purie)



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